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The web of kinship among the Tallensi

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Our discussion has been concerned with the relationship of a person to his or her own father's sister, and we have noted that the bonds of sentiment between father's sister and brother's child seldom extend beyond the nuclear lineage of the latter. A person recognizes the sister of any man in the inner lineage or medial lineage whom he calls 'father' as his *ba-p(ɔ)k*. But whereas a woman has a strong personal interest in and often affection for her full or half-brother's children, and generally also takes a personal interest in her father's brothers' sons' children, the tendency is for the relationship to become more formal beyond that range. This is largely due to the fact that contacts between a woman and the children of her distant brothers of the same inner or medial lineage are usually rare, as compared with her contacts with children of her own nuclear lineage. But the appropriate norms of behaviour hold to the limits of the range of recognized generation differences and may be evoked in suitable circumstances. Beyond the range of the inner, or at most medial lineage, a woman of a person's father's generation is not recognized as a *ba-p(ɔ)k*, but is described as a 'sister' (*tau*) and thus classed with all the non-specifically related clanswomen.

604
[Avuncular And
Nepotic Relatives](#)

A woman calls her brothers' children's children her grandchildren (*yaas*), and she may be very fond of them, if she has opportunities of seeing them often. Gɔlima, a childless old widow who had come to live out the last few years of her life at her oldest brother's house, was often teased good-humouredly by her brothers and brothers' sons because of her attachment to the latter's small children. In theory the joking relationship holds for granchild and grandfather's sister. In practice it is modified by the tendency to class together father's sisters and agnatic grandfather's sisters, who are usually described by the term *ba-p(ɔ)k* or its equivalent *pug(ə)r(ə)ba*. A person

603
[Grandparents And
Grandchildren](#)

604
[Avuncular And
Nepotic Relatives](#)

identifies himself (or herself) with his father in relation to the latter's father's sister, not only on account of the dominance of the lineage principle, but also, and mainly, because he does so in relation to the woman's husband and children. He thinks of the woman's husband as an 'in-law (*deema*)' and of her children as *ah(ə)s*. And this is facilitated by residential separation and the identification of an old woman with the affairs and interests of her husband's lineage and clan. Thus cases like that of Gɔlima are the exception. The majority of old women see so little of their brothers' grandchildren that their relationship with them is purely formal and perfunctory.

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